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.... this is not a history, for the outlines of that see “counting Australia in” 2007, by Graeme Cohen. That book starts before 1788! and has a chapter on mathematics in the ACT. I will mostly just mention the Departments of which I was a member, so this is just one of many paths through the mathematical undergrowth at ANU.

1970's

I started in the Department of Pure Mathematics in the School of General Studies [SGS] in November 1974.

The other Pure Maths Dept at ANU in 1974 was in the Institute for Advanced Studies. There were also two Depts of Applied maths, one in SGS and one in the Institute). The Head and Professor of Pure maths in SGS was Neil Trudinger, appointed while still in his 20's.

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The first difference between then and now was that there were relatively fewer mathematicians around, and it was not unusual to obtain a tenured position straight from a PhD.

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In the 1970's the 2 Maths Dept here in the SGS were housed in the Hanna Neumann building, there was no Manning Clark centre, and the view was directly across a field to Sullivans Creek. Morning and afternoon tea for the Arts Faculty, and Maths, was provided by the University in a large common room. Almost everyone went regularly. Initially we were paid wages in cash every two weeks in the same room. No guards initially, but a lot of cash was certainly around.

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By the end of the 70's the tenured members of the Dept were Neil, Neville Smythe, Martin Ward, John Cossey, Bob Bryce, Algy Howe, Rick Loy, Tom Donaldson and myself. Tom was perhaps the most eccentric mathematician I had met. He was the founder of the Australian cryonics society, and published and publicised widely on the matter.

[Cryonics involves being frozen immediately after death, for preservation until technology improves to the point where the brain and the information therein can be recovered. Tom's office was next to mine, and he had an extremely loud voice when agitated. In one conversation with customs department he was trying to organise the export of a body to the US. I could only hear one side of the conversation, but it seemed he could not get the person at the other end to understand the point. Yes, my body, he was shouting. A few of us from the Dept went to an Orientation Day lecture by Tom for incoming first year students to discuss the freezing process, complete with film and technical details. It was not very successful, I think only one student came. Tom had a successful freezing and is now in Arizona. You can look it up in Wikipedia.]

Turf wars. The then Head of Applied maths, Archie Brown, was not happy when some of us in Pure Maths wanted to organise a seminar on general relativity. Eventually we solved the problem by calling it a seminar on Differential Geometry, but faculty in Applied Maths were not allowed to count it towards “Professional Development”.

1980's In 1982 the Depts of Pure and Applied Maths in SGS, by then the Faculties, were (re)amalgamated. Archie Brown retired and Michael Barber became head of the combined Department.

The CMA, Centre for Mathematical Analysis, began operations. Neil was the founder and Director, and the CMA has had an enduring effect to this day. Peter Price played a major role in drawing all the proposal information together. Bob Anderssen and Frank de Hoog at CSIRO, Richard Brent, and Alan McIntosh then at Macquarie, were strongly associated.

Leon Simon, at the ANU from 1981 — 1990, then Stanford, was a driving force, from organising the famous Friday afternoon seminars to organising sporting events (cricket, volleyball), — he was very competitive! Gerhard Huisken and Alan Carey were two of many post docs here then.

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The CMA office catered for a much smaller group of people then than are around now — Marilyn Gray as administrator had a constant supply of brewed coffee for the regular stream of faculty and students in and out.

Friday evening, most people in maths in the Faculties and the Institute, with spouses would adjourn for drinks at the staff club, dinner afterwards, BBQ's on the Island, swimming out and back, it was highly and drinkably sociable.

The School of Mathematical Sciences SMS began in 1989, comprising the Dept of Maths in the Faculties, the CMA, and both the Maths Dept and the Stats Dept from the Institute. This was the first major integration of Faculty and Institute components at the ANU

1990's Late 80's & 90's, email and personal computers were becoming available. This was making a big change in ease of accessing information!

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In 1991 the CMA external funding finished and the CMA morphed into the Centre for Mathematics and its Applications, still CMA. It obtained other external but more piece-meal funding, broadened its activities and sponsored a wide range of workshops and other activities.

ARC large grant funding started to become much more of a pressure. As always now, making an argument about applications of one's work was important.

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2000's

In 2002 the SMS was renamed as the MSI, Mathematical Sciences Institute